

Conservation Updates

Where in the World are Len and Lola?

Bald Eagle Conservation through Research and Education

By Amber Rosintoski, Wild Wings Educator, photos by Shari Lambeth



The newest eaglet, hatched on March 9, 2008, was named in memory of Letha Fields, a dedicated staff member who had been a part of the Visitor Services team for more than ten years. Letha unfortunately passed away on April 23, 2008 just two days after putting the eaglet into her backing tower.

Carolina Raptor Center is a non-profit organization dedicated to environmental education and the conservation of birds of prey through public education, the rehabilitation of injured and orphaned raptors and research. For many years the Bald Eagle (*Haliaeetus leucocephalus*) residents in the Betty J. & J. Stanley Livingstone eagle aviary at Carolina Raptor Center have laid eggs, but it wasn't until March of 2006 that any of the eggs hatched. During daily feeding rounds, one of CRC's volunteers discovered a small ball of fluff in the eagle nest. The first captive eaglet hatched in North Carolina hatched out on March 4, 2006 followed by the second on March 5, 2006. Over the last three years, six eaglets have hatched in captivity in North Carolina at Carolina Raptor Center.

Thanks to the support of numerous community organizations, we were able to purchase two GPS tracking devices that have given us the opportunity to monitor the locations of our first two eaglets released in 2006, Len and Lola. With this incredible technology, the journeys of Len and Lola will be able to give students a science experience that will remain with them for the rest of their lives. Carolina Raptor Center will soon offer a year-long curriculum for fifth graders that will open their eyes to environmental stewardship and conservation. This new program is important because it addresses the concerns of teachers who feel unable to focus on conservation in their classroom because it is not written into the state standards. The Eagle Tracking Curriculum will allow teachers to use actual scientific data to present key concepts necessary to send their students into the next grade level, while simultaneously introducing them to important environmental concerns.

Len and Lola's journey will change the way some of these children feel about the environment forever. Over the course of the year, students will spend time writing research papers, developing computer skills and solving math equations, all while following the routes of these eagles' journeys. Students will gain a working knowledge of important scientific tools as they use GIS systems to track Len and Lola's specific locations and plug into Google Earth to find potential hazards along their migratory routes. Students will also be given the opportunity to visit Carolina Raptor Center where they will meet some raptors up close, including Len and Lola's parents. Our hope is to create an appreciation for the natural world, and we believe this curriculum will be an effective tool for teaching younger generations how they can help raptors and the environment.

For more information about Eagle Journeys log onto our website at: www.carolinaraptorcenter.org

Do you know of any conservation news to share with members? Email the information to flyer@iaute.org

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